For eight years leading up to war in 1962, India and China poked and prodded each other at the boundary. Beijing had accused India in 1954 of violating the border at Barahoti in the middle sector; in 1955, Delhi returned the compliment by accusing Chinese troops of entering Indian territory in the area. A series of minor incursions followed in Barahoti, leading to four years of intermittent discussions between Delhi and Beijing. By 1959, all three sectors – Aksai Chin in the west, NEFA in the east, and the middle sector – were the site of confrontations. One reason for this was that Chinese troops were pushing forward as they dealt with the Tibetan uprising. At any rate, tit-for-tat accusations of intrusions and provocations intensified in the ensuing three years.

Thus, in June 1959, China accused India of intruding at Migyitun and further to the north-east in the eastern sector. Delhi eventually accepted that its forces had mistakenly moved north of the McMahon Line to Tamaden, and it pulled them back. On 28 July, India protested the detention of an Indian patrol in Ladakh. On 7 August, Delhi claimed a fracas occurred at Khinzemane in the eastern sector. This was followed by the most serious clash, at Longju in the eastern sector on 25 August. In a conversation with Khrushchev some weeks later, Mao accepted that China had fired first at Longju but insisted that Chinese actions there were ordered by local commanders. Beijing claimed too that the incident was related to India's prior aggression at Migyitun. In September 1961, there was trouble at Chip Chap in the western sector when Chinese troops tried to capture a post. This was followed by fighting at Kongka, again in the western sector, on 20–21 October: India accused China of ambushing a patrol; China claimed India had started it by more aggressive patrolling. Beijing warned Delhi that if Indian patrols continued to intrude in Ladakh, Chinese troops might do the same in the eastern sector.

With domestic pressure building on the Indian government to respond to China's incursions, Nehru announced the Forward Policy in November 1961 – the advance of Indian troops and the setting up of posts to exert control over territories that India claimed. Whatever China may have thought, it is hard to see that these moves were intended to dislodge Tibet